

Seventy-Five Years, One Region

Lesson 41 — Essay practice: closing the Middle East regional study

What you will know and be able to do

- 1 Write a complete, timed essay drawing on the Arab Spring block, Lessons 38–40
- 2 Synthesise the entire Middle East regional study across all 36 lessons
- 3 Self-assess against every skill built since Lesson 1
- 4 Close this regional in-depth topic ready to begin African independence movements

From 1945 to the collapse of a caliphate

Thirty-six lessons have carried us from the mandate system's unfinished business through Nasser, Iran's revolution, Gulf oil politics, failed peace processes, and finally the Arab Spring's uprisings and their most extreme consequence. Today's practice tests the Arab Spring specifically, before we step back to survey the whole regional study.

A full argument-evaluation essay

“The Arab Spring's most consequential outcome was not any single government's fall, but the demonstration that popular uprisings could reshape the region as decisively as foreign intervention or authoritarian rule ever had.” To what extent do you agree?

A representative Paper 3 style question drawing on Lessons 38–40.

PRACTICE • 40 MIN

Write your complete essay now

Write a full essay in response to today's question, under real time pressure, without looking back at earlier lesson slides until you finish.

- Plan your position and structure before writing a single sentence
- Use specific evidence from at least three of Lessons 38–40
- Integrate at least one genuine historiographical reference
- Reach a real, specific judgement in your conclusion

Checking your own essay

Did you weigh Tunisia's success against Libya, Syria, and ISIS's very different trajectories, rather than treating the Arab Spring as a single, uniform event? Did you address the claim's specific comparison — popular uprisings versus foreign intervention and authoritarian rule — rather than simply describing what happened? Did your conclusion reach a genuine judgement?

What connects 1945 to 2017

Look back across all thirty-six lessons. A single thread runs through nearly every episode: the tension between externally imposed structures — colonial borders, Cold War alliances, oil-funded stability — and internally generated demands for self-determination, dignity, and religious or national identity. Nasser, Khomeini, Oslo, Hamas, and the Arab Spring are all, in different ways, responses to that same underlying tension.

Four concepts across seven blocks

CAUSE AND CONSEQUENCE / CONTINUITY AND CHANGE

- Mandate-era contradictions shaping decades of later conflict
- The 1973 war's political capital enabling Camp David
- Colonial borders persisting, then explicitly rejected by ISIS

PERSPECTIVES / SIGNIFICANCE

- The Nakba and Israel's War of Independence: one event, opposite meanings
- Camp David 2000's contested pro-Israeli and pro-Palestinian accounts
- Oil's dual role as both stabilising force and destabilising trigger

A toolkit built across thirty-six lessons

Kedourie versus Hourani on Arab nationalism's authenticity. Israel's 'New Historians' revising 1948. Competing accounts of Camp David 2000's failure. Marc Sageman's scepticism about Al-Qaeda's coherence as an organisation. Debates over the 2003 invasion's true motive. Each remains available as a genuine, specific reference for essays on either of this course's regional in-depth topics.

The habits worth carrying forward

Answering the general topic instead of the specific claim asked. Listing causes without weighing them against an explicit criterion. Treating historiography as decoration rather than genuine engagement. Forgetting that 'balanced' does not mean 'equally important'. All four have been flagged since Lesson 1, and all four continue to determine whether an essay reaches the top mark band.

The Middle East regional study, in one glossary

Mandate contradiction

Britain's incompatible promises regarding Palestine's future, still felt in 2011 and beyond.

Rentier bargain

Oil wealth exchanged for political quiescence, tested by the Arab Spring.

Tactical defeat, strategic victory

The recurring pattern from Suez to the 1973 crossing.

Colonial border rejection

ISIS's explicit, symbolic attack on the region's Sykes-Picot map.

Seventy-five years, never fully settled

From 1945 to the 2017 fall of Mosul, no single settlement, revolution, or intervention in this regional study ever produced a lasting, uncontested resolution. Every apparent ending — armistice, ceasefire, treaty, caliphate collapse — opened directly onto the next chapter's instability. Keep this pattern in mind as you now turn to a very different set of countries facing comparable questions.

The Middle East regional study, block by block

Foundations, 1945–52

Mandate contradictions, the 1948 war, and Egypt's fall of its monarchy.

Nasser and Arab nationalism

Suez, the UAR, Yemen, and the 1967 defeat.

The conflict after 1967

Attrition, 1973, the oil weapon, and Camp David.

Iran, 1953–81

Coup, reform, revolution, and the hostage crisis.

The final three blocks

Gulf politics and oil

Rentier stability, OPEC, and two devastating wars.

After the Gulf War

Oslo, political Islam, 2003, and Al-Qaeda.

The Arab Spring

Tunisia and Egypt's uprisings, Libya and Syria's divergence, and ISIS's rise and fall.

What was likely, and what depended on specific choices

Some form of tension between imposed borders and internal identity was always likely, given the mandate system's contradictions. But the specific sequence — Suez rather than a different crisis, Khomeini's clerical state rather than a more pluralist alternative, ISIS rather than a different extremist group entirely — depended on particular individuals' choices at particular moments. Holding both together, rather than picking one explanation exclusively, is the mark of a genuinely sophisticated essay.

Before and after 1979

BEFORE THE IRANIAN REVOLUTION

- Secular Arab nationalism as the region's dominant political language
- Superpower rivalry organised primarily around Cold War alliance blocs
- Political Islam present, but not yet a dominant alternative force

AFTER THE IRANIAN REVOLUTION

- Political Islam increasingly rivalling secular nationalism across the region
- A new, explicitly religious axis of regional rivalry, alongside Cold War alignment
- Iran itself as an active exporter of revolutionary ideology, not just a Cold War client

A genuine turning point, not just a convenient date

1979 is not simply a memorable year — it marks a real shift in the region's dominant political vocabulary, visible in Hamas and Hezbollah's later emergence, in Gulf monarchies' anxious response to Iranian influence, and in Al-Qaeda's own ideological lineage. Essays that recognise 1979 as this kind of hinge point, rather than treating all seventy-five years as a single undifferentiated era, demonstrate a stronger grasp of the period's actual shape.

Your own thirty-second summary

Before moving to Africa, try summarising this entire regional study in three sentences, out loud, without notes. If you can explain the mandate system's legacy, the 1979 turning point, and the Arab Spring's mixed outcomes concisely and accurately, you have genuinely internalised this topic — not just accumulated facts about it.

What this entire regional study was really testing

Not just seventy-five years of Middle Eastern history, but the ability to construct a disciplined, evidenced argument in direct response to a specific claim — weighing cause and consequence, continuity and change, perspectives, and significance with precision, and engaging genuinely with how historians themselves have argued about this contested, still-unfolding region.

Lesson 42 — Colonial Africa before independence movements

Next lesson starts Block C: our second regional in-depth topic, covering independence movements in Algeria, Angola, Ghana, Guinea, Namibia, and Tanganyika — six very different paths out of colonial rule on the same continent.